HIDDENATLAS

CURATED TRAVEL GUIDE

PHILIPPINES · PALAWAN

Philippines

17 Day Island Journey

DESTINATION	DURATION	IDEAL FOR
Philippines, Palawan	17 Days • 15 Nights	2–6 people

YOUR JOURNEY

Expedition Route

Philippines · Palawan · 17 Days • 15 Nights

DAY 1
Manila

DAY 2
Manila · San Vicente · Long Beach

DAY 3
San Vicente · Long Beach

DAY 4
San Vicente · El Nido

DAY 5
El Nido · Miniloc Island · Big Lagoon

DAY 6
El Nido · Secret Lagoon · Shimizu Island

DAY 7
El Nido · Nacpan Beach

DAY 8
El Nido · Bacuit Archipelago

DAY 9
El Nido · Coron

DAY 10
Coron · Kayangan Lake · Twin Lagoon

DAY 11
Coron · Coron Bay · Shipwrecks

DAY 12
Coron · Busuanga · Boracay · White Beach

DAY 13
Boracay · Puka Shell Beach · Diniwid

DAY 14
Boracay · Ariel's Point

DAY 15
Boracay · Caticlan · Manila · Makati

DAY 16
Manila · Intramuros · BGC

DAY 17
Manila

JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- San Vicente's Long Beach: a 14 kilometre arc of undeveloped white sand facing the South China Sea
- Kayangan Lake in Coron, consistently voted the cleanest lake in Asia
- Twin Lagoon: two lagoons connected by a limestone arch you swim through
- El Nido's Bacuit Archipelago: private boat through the limestone karst islands and hidden lagoons
- Coron's WWII Japanese shipwrecks, among the world's best wreck dives at 10 to 40 metres
- Boracay's Puka Shell Beach and the island's quiet northern shore

DAY 1

Arrival in Manila

Land at Ninoy Aquino International Airport and settle into accommodation near the terminal. Manila does not need to be decoded in a single evening, and the plan does not ask you to try. The airport area offers reliable hotels and enough good eating within a short ride to make a first meal in the Philippines worth remembering.

- Ninoy Aquino International Airport: the main international gateway to the Philippines
- Airport district restaurants: a first dinner in the Philippines without the pressure of a city itinerary
- Manila Bay at sunset: visible on the approach road, a preview of the coastal light that follows throughout the route

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DAY 2

Manila to San Vicente — Long Beach Arrival

The morning flight to San Vicente arrives at one of the least known beaches in Southeast Asia. Long Beach runs for 14 kilometres along the northwest coast of Palawan, backed by coconut groves and undeveloped aside from a handful of small guesthouses. The sand is white, the water is clear, and there is almost no infrastructure in the sense that modern beach tourism normally provides. This is the Philippines before the hotels arrived.

- San Vicente, Palawan: a small municipality on the northwest coast, almost entirely undiscovered by mass tourism
- Long Beach: 14 kilometres of white sand, one of the longest undeveloped beaches in Asia
- Port Barton area: the cluster of small settlements at the beach's southern approach, with simple accommodation and good seafood

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DAY 3

San Vicente — A Day on Long Beach

A full day on a beach that asks nothing of you. The rhythm of Long Beach is set by the tide and the light, not by schedules. Walk the length of it in the morning when the sand is still cool. Rent a kayak in the afternoon and paddle along the coast. The local fishermen work the channel behind the beach at low tide and will often sell fresh catch directly from the boat. This is slow travel in the most literal sense.

- Long Beach at low tide: the sandbar extends several hundred metres, the water knee deep and clear
- Kayaking along the coast: the islands visible offshore from Long Beach are accessible by paddle
- Maoyon River mouth: the mangrove estuary at the beach's northern end, reachable by kayak
- Sunset on Long Beach: the western exposure makes this one of the finest sunset vantage points in Palawan

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DAY 4

San Vicente to El Nido — Arrival

Transfer north to El Nido by shared van or private car along Palawan's coast road, passing through small towns and stretches of forest where the jungle comes down to the road. El Nido sits at Palawan's northern tip, surrounded on three sides by the karst limestone towers of the Bacuit Archipelago. Arriving in the late afternoon, the first view of the bay from the town waterfront is the orienting moment: the islands are out there, and tomorrow the boats go out.

- El Nido town: the small settlement at Palawan's northern tip, the gateway to the Bacuit Archipelago
- Bacuit Bay: the sheltered bay facing the fifty-island archipelago, visible from the waterfront
- Las Cabanas Beach: the sunset beach south of town, reached by tricycle in under fifteen minutes
- The El Nido waterfront: where the bancas depart each morning for the archipelago tours

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DAY 5

El Nido — Big Lagoon and Small Lagoon

The first day out on the water. Private banca through the Bacuit Archipelago to Miniloc Island: the Big Lagoon, its turquoise water enclosed by vertical limestone walls that rise forty metres from the surface. At low tide a gap in the rock opens into the Small Lagoon, accessible only by kayak. Snake Island sandbar in the afternoon: a curved strip of white sand that appears and disappears with the tide. The coral between stops is intact and the fish are plentiful.

- Big Lagoon, Miniloc Island: a turquoise enclosure ringed by vertical limestone, the most photographed lagoon in Palawan
- Small Lagoon: accessible at low tide only, through a narrow passage in the rock wall
- Snake Island sandbar: the curved sand isthmus that appears between two islands at low tide
- Seven Commandos Beach: the white sand beach on Palawan's west coast for the afternoon

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DAY 6

El Nido — Secret Lagoon and Shimizu Island

The second route through the archipelago. Secret Lagoon on Miniloc: reached by squeezing through a crevice in the limestone at low tide into a circular hidden space the size of a small stadium. Shimizu Island for snorkelling over the best coral in the Bacuit Archipelago, the reef intact and the fish density high enough to be disorienting. Matinloc Shrine on its limestone cliff above the Tapiutan Strait. Helicopter Island beach for the afternoon, named for the silhouette visible from above.

- Secret Lagoon: a hidden circular space inside the limestone, entered through a rock crevice at low tide
- Shimizu Island: the best snorkelling reef in the Bacuit Archipelago, with intact coral and dense fish populations
- Matinloc Shrine: the white shrine on a cliff above the strait between Matinloc and Tapiutan islands
- Helicopter Island: the beach below the island silhouette that gives it its name

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DAY 7

El Nido — Nacpan Beach

The day away from the boats. Drive north of El Nido town along a dirt road through coconut groves to Nacpan Beach: four kilometres of white sand facing the South China Sea, with almost no facilities and almost no visitors. One of the finest beaches in the Philippines, and consistently overlooked because the road is rough and the journey requires patience. The Twin Beaches viewpoint connects Nacpan to neighbouring Calitang Beach, the two meeting at a strip of sand passable on foot at low tide.

- Nacpan Beach: four kilometres of undeveloped white sand north of El Nido, facing the South China Sea
- Twin Beaches viewpoint: the hill above where Nacpan and Calitang beaches converge at a low tide sandbar
- Calitang Beach: the neighbouring beach south of the viewpoint, quieter still than Nacpan
- The drive north: a dirt road through coconut groves that filters out everyone unwilling to make the effort

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DAY 8

El Nido — Last Day in the Archipelago

A final morning on the water before the move south. The outer islands of the Bacuit Archipelago, away from the standard tour boat circuits, offer a different quality of silence. A private charter to Cadlao Island or the reefs around Papaya Beach gives access to water and shoreline that the tour groups rarely reach. The afternoon is for El Nido town: the market, a meal, and the last evening watching the limestone towers turn gold.

- Cadlao Island: the largest island in the Bacuit Archipelago, with a lagoon and reef accessible by private charter
- Papaya Beach: a small sandy beach on the outer archipelago, rarely included in standard tour routes
- El Nido market: the small local market behind the main street where the town actually shops
- El Nido town at dusk: the karst towers above the bay catch the last light in a way that justifies the trip

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DAY 9

El Nido to Coron — The Ferry South

Take the fast ferry south from El Nido through the Calamian island group to Coron: a four hour crossing through waters that change character as the Bacuit limestone towers give way to the broader, flatter Busuanga landscape. Coron operates at a different register: the same clarity of water, the same density of islands, but with a history below the surface that El Nido does not have. On 24 September 1944, a US Navy air strike sank 24 Japanese supply ships in Coron Bay, and twelve of them are now among the most extraordinary dive sites in the world.

- El Nido to Coron fast ferry: a four hour crossing through the Calamian island group
- Coron town: the small market settlement on Busuanga Island above the WWII wreck sites
- Coron Bay: the sheltered bay flanked by karst limestone islands, the shipwrecks below the surface
- Mount Tapyas: the hill above Coron town with a concrete staircase to a viewpoint over the bay

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DAY 10

Coron — Kayangan Lake and Twin Lagoon

A twenty minute hike over a limestone ridge on Coron Island leads to Kayangan Lake: a freshwater lake fed by mountain springs and enclosed by vertical stone walls. The water is so clear the bottom is visible at depth, and the lake has been consistently named the cleanest in Asia. Twin Lagoon follows: two lagoons connected by a limestone arch low enough to swim through at high tide, the inner lagoon noticeably warmer than the first. Barracuda Lake in the afternoon, where a thermocline brings two water temperatures together in a single body.

- Kayangan Lake: a freshwater lake inside the limestone karst of Coron Island, consistently voted the cleanest lake in Asia
- Twin Lagoon: two lagoons connected by a submerged rock arch, the inner lagoon noticeably warmer
- Barracuda Lake: a thermocline dive where cold spring water meets warm surface water in the same body
- Coron Island: the ancestral domain of the Tagbanua people, accessible by boat from Coron town

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DAY 11

Coron — The WWII Shipwrecks

The wreck dives. Twelve Japanese supply ships rest in Coron Bay at depths between 10 and 40 metres, their structures colonised by coral and circled by fish in numbers that suggest the wrecks have become the reef they never had. The Okikawa Maru, the Irako, the Morazan Maru. Non-divers can snorkel the shallower sites. There is nothing comparable in Southeast Asia: an entire fleet, still largely intact, given back to the ocean.

- Okikawa Maru: the oil tanker wreck at 10 to 47 metres, the shallowest and most accessible of the fleet
- Irako: the provisioning ship at 40 metres, its structure largely intact after more than eighty years
- Morazan Maru: the largest of the Coron wrecks, resting at 33 metres
- Lusong Gunboat: the Japanese gunboat in 10 metres of water, accessible to snorkellers without dive equipment

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DAY 12

Coron to Boracay — Arrival at White Beach

Fly from Busuanga to Caticlan and take the short banca crossing to Boracay. The island is four kilometres long. White Beach runs along its entire western shore: the four kilometre arc of fine white sand that made Boracay famous in the 1980s and overfamous in the decades that followed. The northern end, Station 1, is quieter, the accommodation more considered, the stretch of beach less managed. This is where the route settles.

- Boracay island: four kilometres long, most development concentrated on White Beach's western shore
- Station 1: the quieter northern end of White Beach, with calmer water and better accommodation options
- D'Mall: the commercial centre of the island, useful for orientation on arrival
- White Beach at sunset: the western exposure that made Boracay famous, a genuinely good sunset regardless of its reputation

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DAY 13

Boracay — Puka Shell Beach and the North

The Boracay most visitors miss. Puka Shell Beach on the island's northern tip is the longest beach on the quiet side: named for the shells that accumulate on its shoreline, with no sunbeds, no vendors, and a quality of emptiness that White Beach stopped offering years ago. Walk south along the coast path to Diniwid Beach, the small cove north of Station 1. Sail the paraw outrigger at sunset: the traditional Filipino wooden canoe that navigates White Beach every evening when the light is right.

- Puka Shell Beach: the undeveloped northern beach, named for its shell covered shoreline, with no facilities
- Diniwid Beach: the small cove north of Station 1, accessible on foot along the coastal path
- Boracay paraw sailing: the traditional twin sail outrigger, the most photographed evening activity on the island
- The coastal path north: a twenty minute walk from Station 1 to Puka Shell Beach along the island's quieter edge

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DAY 14

Boracay — Ariel's Point and the Last Reef

Morning boat to Ariel's Point: the headland off Boracay's north coast with cliff jumps at five different heights, snorkelling over coral the tour boats do not reach, and kayaking around the point to bays accessible only by water. Return for a final afternoon on White Beach. Dinner at the Station 1 end: the restaurants that do not face the sunset strip, with fewer tourists, better kitchens, and prices that reflect the food rather than the view.

- Ariel's Point: the headland day trip with cliff jumps at 3, 5, 8 and 15 metres above the water
- Snorkelling at Ariel's Point: coral accessible only by boat, away from the White Beach reef crowds
- White Beach final afternoon: a last swim on the main beach before the day closes
- Station 1 dining: the quieter northern restaurants where the quality of cooking tends to outperform the strip

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DAY 15

Boracay to Manila — the Return

Ferry from Boracay to Caticlan, then fly to Manila. If the schedule allows, the Makati district is reachable from the airport in under an hour: the most navigable part of Manila, with good hotels, a walkable grid of streets, and restaurants that would hold their own in any city. A final night in the city before the departure tomorrow.

- Boracay to Caticlan ferry: the ten minute banca crossing to the mainland at Malay
- Caticlan to Manila: the domestic flight returning to Ninoy Aquino International Airport
- Makati: Manila's financial district, the city's most ordered neighbourhood and its best food destination
- Greenbelt and Salcedo Village: the walkable dining and park area in the heart of Makati

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DAY 16

Manila — Intramuros and BGC

A final day in Manila with time to use properly. Intramuros in the morning: the Spanish walled city built in 1571, with Fort Santiago, the Cathedral, and the Rizal Shrine telling the city's colonial history in a compact and walkable area. Bonifacio Global City in the afternoon: the contemporary district that opened on the site of the former Fort Bonifacio military base, with rooftop restaurants and a view of the city that makes sense of everything below.

- Intramuros: the Spanish colonial walled city at the mouth of the Pasig River, built in 1571
- Fort Santiago: the 16th-century citadel where José Rizal was imprisoned before his execution in 1896
- Manila Cathedral: the Baroque cathedral rebuilt seven times since 1581, still in use and still impressive
- Bonifacio Global City: the contemporary district on the former US military base, with rooftop restaurants and skyline views

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DAY 17

Departure from Manila

International departure from Ninoy Aquino International Airport. The Philippines stays with you: the colour of the water inside Kayangan Lake, the scale of the limestone towers from a banca in Bacuit Bay, the silence of Long Beach in the early morning before the day has started. Most destinations offer moments. This one offers an accumulation of them.

- NAIA Terminal 1: for most international carriers including Cathay Pacific and Finnair
- NAIA Terminal 3: for Philippine Airlines, Singapore Airlines and major Gulf carriers
- Direct connections to Hong Kong, Singapore, Tokyo, Dubai and major European hub airports

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Our planners can build the personalised version around your dates, travel style and pace.

- Refined route planning and pacing
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